

Victorinus of Poetovio: *On the Creation of the World* (*De fabrica mundi*)

English translation by Luke J. Stevens, 2021

Introduction

To Victorinus of Poetovio, best known for his *Commentary on Revelation* (ca. 260), just one other work is unanimously ascribed, the present *On the Creation of the World*. Coming down to us in a single manuscript, the Latin text has been most recently edited by Gryson,¹ while the lone English translation by Wallis from the nineteenth century leaves much to be desired.² This treatise has seldom received more than passing attention,³ even though it affords an extraordinary window into early Christianity. The text echoes, sometimes in a more primitive form, several distinctive points in Irenaeus, betraying an important common source in the mid-second century.⁴ Though not a proper Hexaemeron, the treatise briefly reflects on how the six days of creation and seventh-day rest relate to the other Scriptures, Christ, and Christian practice.

¹ Roger Gryson, ed., *Victorinus Poetovionensis: Opera quae supersunt*, CCSL 5 (Turnhout: Brepols, 2017), 294–300. Also of great value is the annotated French translation of Martine Dulaey, *Victorin de Poetovio, Sur l'Apocalypse, et autres écrits*, SC 423 (Paris: Cerf, 1997), 138–49, 215–31.

² [ANF 7:341–3](#).

³ Most notably: John Chapman, “Papias on the Age of Our Lord,” *JTS*, o.s., 9 (1907): 42–61; Jean Daniélou, *Les origines du christianisme latin*, Histoire des doctrines chrétiennes avant Nicée 3 (Paris: Cerf, 1978), 114–16; Martine Dulaey, *Victorin de Poetovio, premier exégète latin*, CEASA 139–140 (Paris: Études augustiniennes, 1993), 24–36 and passim.

⁴ Chapman argues that Victorinus is parroting Papias’s lost work, but Luke J. Stevens, “Twenty-Four Elders: Revelation and the Old Testament Canon in Victorinus and Melito,” *J ECS*, forthcoming, instead suggests Melito’s lost *On Creation* as the common source.

Translation

¹ To me, as I ponder some things with my mind, considering the construction of this world in which we are enclosed, even the speed of its construction is this, just as contained in the book of Moses that he wrote about its creation, which is called Genesis: God expressed this whole mass in six days out of nothing into an ornament of his majesty.⁵ Resting from his work, he consecrated the seventh with a blessing. For this reason, therefore, since by the septenary number of days all heavenly and earthly things are ruled, I shall meditate firstly on this week, the queen of all weeks, and I shall try, as much as I can, to express the day of power to its fulfilment.

Ex 20:11

Gen 2:2–3

Ps 109(110):3

² In the beginning God made light and divided it by the duodenary number of hours with day and night. For this reason, it may be seen that the day would bring over the night from labors of men to a place of rest, and that in turn the day would overcome, and thus alternately labor would be refreshed by the night's rest, and rest in turn would be tempered by the day's exercise.

Gen 1:1–3; Jn 11:9

On the fourth day he made two luminaries in the sky, a greater and a lesser, so that the one would preside over the day, the other over the night, that of the sun and that of the moon, and he put the rest of the stars in the sky, that they would shine over the earth and divide the seasons, years, months, days, and hours by their stations.

Gen 1:14–19

³ Now the reason of the truth is shown, why the fourth day is called the Tetrads, why we fast until the ninth hour, or until the evening, or that a superposition is made into another day.⁶ Thus:⁷

- This world consists of four elements—fire, water, sky, earth; these four elements therefore make a tetrad.
- Also, the sun and the moon complete through the space of a year four seasons—of spring, summer, fall, winter; and these seasons make a tetrad.⁸

⁵ Cf. Tertullian, *Apol.* 17.1.

⁶ Already in the *Didache* 8.1, Christian fasting on Wednesday and Friday is opposed to Jewish fasting on Monday and Thursday. The *superposition* (or *hyperthesis*) is a fast extending even into the next day. On these fasting practices, see Dulaey, *Victorin*, 226–31.

⁷ Cf. Irenaeus, *Haer.* 3.11.8; Chromatius, *Tract. Matt.* prol. 4–10; Epiphanius, *Mens.* 35—all presenting series of foursomes as biblical and natural parallels to the four gospels, and all overlapping only partially. The content of Chromatius's passage, undoubtedly reflecting Victorinus's lost *Commentary on the Gospels*, is also reprised in an abbreviated form in Victorinus, *Comm. Apoc.* 2.49–85(4.4).

⁸ Cf. Philo, *Opif.* 52, likewise linking the fourth day of creation with the four elements and four seasons, with reference to his lost treatise *On Numbers*.

And that I may expound from that subject at greater length, behold:

- four living creatures before God’s throne Ezek 1:5; Rev 4:6
- four gospels
- four rivers flowing in paradise Gen 2:10
- four generations of peoples:⁹
 - from Adam to Noah
 - from Noah to Abraham
 - from Abraham to Moses
 - from Moses to Christ the Lord, the Son of God
- [and four living creatures—of man, calf, lion, eagle]¹⁰ Ezek 1:10; Rev 4:7
- and four rivers—Pishon, Gihon, Tigris, and Euphrates]¹¹ Gen 2:11–14

The man Christ Jesus, the author of these things that we have recounted above, was seized on the Tetrads by the ungodly.¹² Thus, because of his capture on the Tetrads, because of the majesty of his works—and so that the seasons may run healthy for humanity, glad for fruits, tranquil for storms—we therefore make <either a station> or a superposition.

⁴ On the fifth day, the earth and the water brought forth their offspring. On the sixth day there were created the things that were lacking, and thus God fashioned man from the soil, as lord of all the things that he created upon the earth and upon the water. Yet he created the angels and archangels before he formed man, putting spiritual things before earthly things, for light is before the sky and earth.¹³ This sixth day is called the Parasceve, that is, the preparation for the kingdom.¹⁴ He finished Adam and Eve in his image and likeness. Yet for this reason Gen 1:20–25
Gen 2:7
Gen 1:28
Gen 1:26–27

⁹ Each generation is inaugurated by one of the four Old Testament men with whom God made a covenant. Clement of Alexandria, *Ecl.* 51.1, refers to the same four covenants and in *Strom.* 5.34.4 identifies them with the four pillars of the temple (almost certainly following Philo’s lost writings). Irenaeus, *Haer.* 3.11.8, refers instead to four pillars of the Church and squeezes the new covenant of Christianity into the foursome at the expense of Abraham (likewise, following him, Methodius, *Symp.* 10.2–3). Origen, *Comm. Matt.* 15.32–33, refers more naturally to five covenantal generations. See J. M. Tevel, “The Labourers in the Vineyard: The Exegesis of Matthew 20,1–7 in the Early Church,” *VC* 46 (1992): 356–80.

¹⁰ This order of the animals is not biblical, but rather corresponds to an exegesis linking them to the principal events of Christ’s life (man, incarnation; calf, sacrifice on the cross; lion, victory over death; eagle, ascension), just as found in Chromatius, *Tract. Matt.* prol. 8 (undoubtedly reflecting Victorinus’s lost *Commentary on the Gospels*) and in an altered form in Victorinus, *Comm. Apoc.* 2.74–82(4.4).

¹¹ These two items are obviously interpolated glosses, listing out the living creatures and rivers already mentioned above.

¹² Jesus’s arrest is situated on the night with which Wednesday (the Tetrads) begins, or Tuesday evening as we would now call it, rather than Thursday evening. The latter view, placing the Last Supper and arrest on the night before the crucifixion, is attested already in Irenaeus, *Haer.* 2.22.3. But the former, along with its connection to the Wednesday fast, is also affirmed in *Did. apost.* 21, Epiphanius, *De fide* 22.1–2, and elsewhere; see Roelof van den Broek, *Pseudo-Cyril of Jerusalem on the Life and the Passion of Christ: A Coptic Apocryphon*, *VCSup* 118 (Leiden: Brill, 2013), 39–50, 186–89.

¹³ Cf. Augustine, *Civ.* 11.9 (perhaps taking his lead from Victorinus); Epiphanius, *Haer.* 65.4–5. Dulaey, *Victorin*, 247, deduces that the angels’ creation is here put on the fourth day, alongside the stars (cf. *Job* 38:7).

¹⁴ Preparation for the sabbath, with the true sabbath identified below with the millennial kingdom.

he finished his works before creating the angels and constructing man, lest they perhaps assert falsely that they had been helpers.¹⁵ On this day also, because of the passion of the Lord Jesus Christ, we make either a station to God or a fast.

⁵ On the seventh day, he rested from all his works and blessed and sanctified it. On this day we are accustomed to make a superposition, so that on the Lord's Day we may go out with thanksgiving to the bread.¹⁶ And let there be on the Parasceve a superposition, lest we seem to observe something with the Jews as a sabbath, which the Lord of the sabbath himself, Christ, says through his prophets that his soul hates, the sabbath that he has abolished with his body.¹⁷

Gen 2:2–3

Mt 12:8; Is 1:13–14

Heb 10:10; Eph 2:14–15

Yet previously, while he himself commanded Moses that circumcision not miss the eighth day, which often falls on the sabbath day, just as we read written in the Gospel, Moses, foreseeing the hardness of that people, for this reason raised his hands on the day of the sabbath¹⁸ and crucified himself¹⁹ in the battle by the foreigners on the sabbath, so that they would capture them and by the austerity of the law form them to avoid punishment.

Lev 12:3

Jn 7:22

Ex 17:8–13

⁶ And thus, David in the sixth Psalm for the eighth day asks the Lord that neither in his anger nor in his fury would he reprove or judge him. For this is in fact the eighth day of that future judgement, which is to go beyond the order of the septenary economy. Also, Joshua, son of Nun, Moses's successor, himself abolished the sabbath too; for on the day of the sabbath he commanded the sons of Israel to circle the walls of the city of Jericho with trumpets and declare war on the foreigners. Moreover, Mattathias, prince of Judah, abolished the sabbath; for he killed the prefect of Antiochus, king of Syria, on the sabbath and subdued the foreigners by his pursuit. And in Matthew we read written: <... >

Ps 6:1(–2)

Jos 6:1–21

1 Mac 2:25, 41, 47

Mt 12:3–5

Furthermore, Isaiah and the rest of his fellows abolished the sabbath so that the true and righteous sabbath would be observed in the seventh millenary of years, wherefore the Lord assigned to those seven days a thousand years each. For thus it is decreed: *In your eyes, Lord, a thousand years are as one day*. Therefore, in God's eyes they constitute a thousand years each. For there are seven eyes of the Lord, wherefore, as I have recounted, that true sabbath is the seventh millenary, in which Christ is to reign with his elect.²⁰

Is 1:13; Hos 2:11

Ps 89(90):4; 2 Pet 3:8

Zech 4:10

Rev 20:2–6

¹⁵ Cf. Irenaeus, *Haer.* 2.2.4; Genesis Rabbah 1.3.

¹⁶ I.e., the eucharist—a term literally meaning *thanksgiving*.

¹⁷ Among the several comparable testimonia collections against the Jewish sabbath, none overlap with the present one at more than a few points; see Dulaey, *Victorin*, 275–76.

¹⁸ Situating this battle on the sabbath is unparalleled; see Dulaey, *Victorin*, 112–13.

¹⁹ Cf. Barn. 12; Justin, *Dial.* 90; Irenaeus, *Epid.* 46.

²⁰ World history spans seven millennia—chronographers following the LXX placed Christ amidst the sixth, still ongoing in Victorinus's time—with the seventh as the millennial kingdom foretold in Revelation. This schema comports with chiliast views, without necessarily implying them; see Dulaey, *Victorin*, 108, 255–67. Cf. Barn. 15; *Did. apost.* 6.18; Irenaeus, *Haer.* 5.28.3, 5.33.2; Hippolytus, *Comm. Dan.* 4.23.

⁷ Also, the seven heavens comport with those days. For thus it is decreed: *By the word of the Lord the heavens were established, and by the spirit of his mouth all their power; these are the seven spirits. Their names are the spirits that rested upon the Christ of God, as in Isaiah the prophet it is decreed: And upon him rests the spirit of wisdom and of understanding, the spirit of counsel and of power, the spirit of knowledge and of godliness, and the spirit of fear of God has filled him. Therefore:*²¹

Ps 32(33):6

Is 11:2-3

- the top heaven, of wisdom
- the second, of understanding
- the third, of counsel
- the fourth, of power
- the fifth, of knowledge
- the sixth, of godliness
- the seventh, of fear of God

Out of the latter, therefore:

- thunders roar
- lightnings are spread out
- fires are amassed
- fiery beams appear
- stars shine
- dreadful rays flash
- sometimes it even happens that the sun and moon visit each other and bring about those lights, beyond terrifying, shining on the edge of its visage²²

Yet the author of this whole creation is surnamed the Word. For thus his Father says: *My heart has emitted a good word.* John the Evangelist says thus: *In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God; he was in the beginning with God. Everything was made through him, and without him nothing was made.* Therefore, he was the first made of creation, the second of the man of the human race, as the Apostle says. This Word, therefore:²³

Ps 44:2(45:1); Jn 1:1-3

Col 1:15; 1 Cor 15:47

- when he makes light, is called wisdom
- when the sky, understanding
- when the earth and sea, counsel
- when the sun and moon and the rest of the bright things, power
- when he calls forth of the earth and sea, knowledge
- when he formed man, godliness
- when he blesses and sanctifies man, he has the name fear of God

Wis 7:10; Eccl 2:13

Ps 135(136):5

Is 40:12-13

Ps 32(33):6

Job 39:1-4

Is 17:7

Ps 111(112):1

²¹ Cf. Irenaeus, *Epid.* 9.

²² The solar corona.

²³ In this unique development, the biblical basis is not always readily discernible; see Dulaey, *Victorin*, 237.

8 Behold:²⁴

- seven horns of the Lamb Rev 5:6
- seven eyes of God Zech 3:9
- seven eyes of tin Zech 4:10
- seven eyes Rev 5:6
- seven spirits Rev 4:5, 5:6
- seven burning torches before God's throne Rev 4:5
- seven golden lampstands Ex 25:37; Rev 1:12

- seven lambs Lev 23:18; Num 28:11
- seven women in Isaiah²⁵ Is 4:1
- seven churches in Paul²⁶
- seven deacons Act 6:3
- seven angels Tob 12:15; Rev 8:2
- seven trumpets Jos 6:4; Rev 8:2
- seven seals of the book Rev 5:1

- seven weeks by which Pentecost is defined Lev 23:15–16
- seven weeks in Daniel (likewise sixty-three weeks in Daniel) Dan 9:24–27
- seven of every clean thing in Noah's ark Gen 7:2
- seven vengeance of Cain Gen 4:15
- seven years of debt to be remitted Deut 15:1
- the lamp with seven openings Zech 4:2
- seven pillars of wisdom in the house of Solomon Prov 9:1

9 Now, therefore, may you see recounted the ineffable glory and providence of God: yet, as my small mind will be able, I shall try to show it. His refashioning Adam through the week and rescuing his entire creation was done by the birth of his Son, Jesus Christ, our Lord. And so, who, learned in God's Law, who, full of the Holy Spirit, might not in his heart regard these?²⁷—

²⁴ Here are 7×3 sevens; however, dismissing the final *seven eyes* as a scribal error, Dulaey, *Victorin*, 35, sees here four pentads, each dedicated to a theme: the Spirit and the Word, the Church, the completion of time, and salvation in the Church. This collection of biblical sevens has several parallels clearly related to it, although in every case the overlap is only partial: Cyprian, *Test.* 1.20 and *Fort.* 11 (Chapman, "Papias," 43–44, argues for Victorinus's independence from them, despite the contrary assumption of Dulaey, *Victorin*, 302–4); Victorinus, *Comm. Apoc.* 1.89–123(1.6–7); Fortunatian, *Comm. ev. M.* 81; Gregory of Elvira, *Arca* 7–8—these last two undoubtedly drawing from Victorinus's lost writings.

²⁵ Cf. Victorinus, *Comm. Apoc.* 1.110–123(1.7).

²⁶ The Pauline corpus of letters addresses seven churches, just as John does in Revelation (*Rev* 1:4)—a point found in all the other aforementioned parallels, as well as the *Muratorian Fragment* (likely excerpted from Victorinus's lost writings), but best developed in Victorinus, *Comm. Apoc.* 1.96–109(1.7); yet outside the Latin tradition, the point also occurs in Ps.-Hippolytus, *Chapters against Gaius*, apud Dionysius bar Šalibi, *Comm. Apoc.* 1.4.

²⁷ This remarkable development, for the most part unparalleled, seems to link primordial events to the events of Christ's life through their respective days of the week (though how literally is unclear).

- On the day that the angel Gabriel evangelized the Virgin Mary —on that day, the dragon²⁸ deceived Eve. Lk 1:19
Gen 3:13
- On the day that the Holy Spirit inundated the Virgin Mary —on that, he made light. Lk 1:35
Day 1
- On the day that he was changed into flesh —on that, he made the earth and water. Day 3
- On the day that he was changed into milk²⁹ —on that, he made the stars. Day 4
- On the day into blood —on that, the earth and water brought forth their offspring. Day 5
- On the day that he was changed into flesh —on that, he constructed man from the soil. Day 6
- On the day that he was born the Christ —on that, he formed man.
- On the same day that he suffered —on that, Adam fell.³⁰ Gen 2:17
- On the day that he rose from the dead —on that, he made light. Day 1

Furthermore, he completes his humanity by the septenary number:³¹

- of birth
- of infancy
- of boyhood
- of adolescence
- of youth
- of complete age
- of death

²⁸ The serpent is identified with the dragon, as in Irenaeus, *Haer.* 3.23.7.

²⁹ This embryonic progression as milk → blood → flesh is unparalleled, apart from Augustine, *Div. quaest.* 56 (perhaps depending partly upon Victorinus); see Dulaey, *Victorin*, 307n66.

³⁰ *Cecidit* here could mean either *died* or simply *fell* (from innocence into sin); on the latter, cf. Eve's transgression already mentioned. Cf. Irenaeus, *Haer.* 5.23.2, where Adam's death on a Friday is inferred from his sin on a Friday, yet without adducing any basis for the Friday date.

³¹ Cf. Irenaeus, *Haer.* 2.22.4, 2.24.4. The latter passage, in fact, insists upon precisely *five* stages of life—amidst a series of biblical and natural fives rivaling the present treatise's series of fours and sevens—as does the former, applied to Christ, in two different ways. See the analysis of Chapman, "Papias," 53–61. Among the various ancient ways of dividing human life into stages, some reckon seven (e.g., Ps.-Hippocrates apud Philo, *Opif.* 105), but none quite match the present scheme.

To the Jews he has also shown his humanity in these ways:

- when he was hungry Mt 4:2
- he was thirsty Jn 4:7, 19:28
- he ate food Lk 7:34
- and he drank drink
- he walked Mt 4:18
- and he withdrew Mt 4:12
- when he slept on a pillow Mk 4:38

Yet when:

- he enters the storm-raised seas on his feet Jn 6:18–19
- he commands the winds Lk 8:24
- the sick, he heals Mt 12:15
- and the lame, he restores Mt 15:31
- the blind, <he illuminates
- the deaf, he gives hearing Mk 7:37
- the mute,> he provides speech

—see that he declares to them that he is the Lord.

¹⁰ By the duodenary number, the day, as I have recounted above, is divided through twelve hours into two parts: of light and of night. For through these hours the months and years and seasons and ages are computed. And so, there are constituted without doubt twelve angels of the day, twelve angels of the night, of course for the number of hours. For these are the twenty-four witnesses of the days and nights who sit before the throne of God, having golden crowns on their heads, whom the Apocalypse of John, the Apostle and Evangelist, calls elders, for the reason that they are older than both the other angels and men.³²

Jn 11:9

Rev 4:4

³² Contrast Victorinus, *Comm. Apoc.* 2.45–116(4.3–5), where the twenty-four elders are interpreted in two other ways: as the twenty-four Old Testament books or as the twelve patriarchs and twelve apostles. Although Dulaey, *Victorin*, 25–26, attempts to reconcile them, it is simpler to suppose that Victorinus has reprised from his source a distinct interpretation even more ancient than the other two.